Subject : 77039_1_1 Actors i Règims of Global Governance

Name of the course : Cities

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Title of the Essay : The Belt and Road Initiative as Geo-Urban Strategy: How China's City-Centric Power policy reshapes Global Order

Wordcount : 2.555 words

Date of submission : Sunday May, 17th.

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In 2026, nearly 60% of the world population will live in cities. It was 30% fifteen years ago, and it is expected that by 2050, the world will need to almost double its urban capacity making cities and metropolises, central actors in International Relations (Khanna, 2016). Fernand Braudel, back in 1979, claimed that *cities have always been " [through history] spaces of power"(*1979, p.124). China, aware of this potential, has integrated urbanization into the heart of its geopolitical strategy through the Belt and Road Initiative (BRI),launched in 2013, by president Xi Jinping. More than a simple economic project, it is a network of interconnected urban hubs, designed to extend its global influence. In China nowadays, local governments (like provinces and cities) handle 85% of public expenditure, making them key players in the national plan (Bräutigam, 2019). The BRI is not merely economic but a geo-urban strategy, linking hubs to reshape global power (Khanna, 2016) . The Belt and Road initiative, is much more than an economic partnership, or even a merging economical projection of Chinese interests : it is a spatial reorganization, and geo-urban strategy and a series of hubs, that are interconnected in order to redefine the world's equilibrium. Each city becomes a strategic node to control merchandise flows, a laboratory of social and geostrategical experiences, and a power lever for China throughout the world that define her own definition of power, in one's own image, in International Relations.

But before that, it is crucial to define key international context. Urbanization today is no longer a passive phenomenon, rather, it shapes international diplomacy, amid growing fragmentation , from a multipolar to a multiplex world system.(Acharya, 2023). Therefore, cities are becoming not only a big demographical concentration of manpower and capital, but localities of power where cultural, economical and political flows articulate. Following Saskia Sassen theory *(The Global City)* ,urban centers function not merely as national territories but as command nodes within transnational economic systems. The core example would be Shanghai, being the first, or, second depending on the source, world maritime bay, a technological laboratory (facial recognition) and a symbolism of Chinese soft power. The BRI uses urbanisation and cities as a tool for power. However, this raises central questions, at different levels, that will be at the core of our reflection :To what extent does China use urbanization through the Belt and Road Initiative as a tool of geopolitical power, and what are the limits of this strategy in the evolving landscape of international relations, and what are the mechanisms, successes, and limitations of this strategy, and finally, does the emergence of urban diplomacy (twin cities, urban networks) mark a structural shift in the study of international relations? This essay argues that the BRI uses cities as geopolitical tools, but faces limits. It also asks whether urban diplomacy marks a structural shift in IR.

I. Urbanisation as a power tool of China through the B&R : Cities as Geopolitical weapons

Building infrastructure is not only the objective of the B&R initiative. It changes the balance of power in the world by building a system of linked cities, where every city acts as a center for economy, an area for testing technology, and a way to exert influence. This approach is based on three main ideas: managing pathways (harbors and routes), promoting a city design (new urban areas), and twin-city relations that work around conventional governments (Office of the Leading Group for the Belt and Road Initiative, 2018)

One of the emblematic examples is the Gwadar hub, Pakistan's maritime hub, in the Arabian Coast of Pakistan, that became throughout the years, the symbol of the achievement of the B&R policy. With a total amount of 2.5 Billion Dollars invested, redistributed, from the port in itself, or the special economic zone (SEZ), shows in itself how Beijing can use a city in a strategy of power. Following the Gwadar Post, media from the SRB Media Group, from 2025 onwards, Gwadar

generated 2 billion dollars for the local economy, and should create up to 15.000 jobs in 2027. (The Gwadar Post, 2025). Moreover, Chinese businesses could obtain a tax holiday for up to 40 years, if they chose to implement it there. The same happens in Europe, with the Duisbourg port in Germany. Duisburg, which is the biggest inland port in Europe, has turned into China's logistics center in the continent. From 2021 to 2024, China invested €170 million to upgrade the infrastructure, enabling 100 trains per week to travel to China (Tandfonline, 2022). By the year 2024, the freight traffic between China and Germany had increased twofold, establishing Duisburg as an important point in the China-Europe route (Mordor Intelligence, 2025). This is all part of a strategy of a *connectivité douce* strategy employed by the Chinese government, meaning that the presence of Chinese infrastructures, and investment, can adapt to local reality, and serve China's power without using force. (Lasserre, 2015). However, this win-win method is not always so easy to implement. What about loss of sovereignty and political decision-making ? In 2017, Sri Lanka, burdened by an $8 billion debt (part of which was owed to China), was forced to cede the port to China Merchants Port Holdings for 99 years in exchange for $1.12 billion (Britannica, 2025; LankaWeb, 2025). This port, expected to reach a capacity of 300,000 TEUs per year by the end of 2025, is now under Chinese management.

While strategic ports allow China to control global flows, its power also extends through sophisticated logistics networks, such as corridors, which help fluid connectivity.

For the analysis of this part, we will see two of the main corridors, even though we acknowledge that China has six main corridors, each one of them, as sophisticated logistical actions, to create an interconnected network of hubs. The first one is the China-Pakistan Economic Corridor (CPEC), one of the biggest projects of the B&R initiative : 62 million of dollars invested from 2015 to today, that has 2.000 km of railroads from Gwadar to China, but the most significant one, that proves the efficiency of the Chinese Foreign Policy, 24% of the global Pakistan GDP depend from it (CPIC Global, 2025). In military spending, the B&R initiative has direct consequences. 82 % of Pakistani military imports, since 2024, are directly related to China. This 'partnership'is key to understanding China's foreign policy within the Belt and Road initiative. This economical partnership of imports and investments, has direct impact into the cities global networks, such as in the program *Eurocities.* These individual country-to-country partnerships, with European countries and China, threaten the deal concluded, even though this is within the multifaceted approach of the EU regarding China. For China, investments in cities, such as Budapest or Duisbourg, are key to maintaining a firm position in the continent, creating more than corridors. This allows China to create links, and to meet European demand for manufactured products and technologies. China is doing more than controlling flows. China is also using urbanization to try out ideas and create a modern way of life. China is building cities that are meant to show the world what China is capable of, in terms of technology and politics.

Following the spirit of the famous Chinese intellectual Lu Xun, who already in the late XIXth, and beginning of the XXst century, interrogated the deep transformation of Chinese society, he understood that modernisation became a weapon of power. Nowadays, the *New Smart Cities* embodies the new strategy of affirmation of Chinese soft power, in between showcases of modernity and laboratories of modernisation.

"New cities" are now emerging as true showcases of sustainable modernity. Designed from scratch or extensively restructured, they offer an ideal testing ground for integrating the principles of sustainable development and technological innovations from the outset. Faced with the challenges of the 21st century—rapid urbanization, climate change, and pressure on resources—these cities are becoming full-scale laboratories where new ways of producing, consuming, and living together are being tested (UN-Habitat, 2020; World Bank, 2019). The example of Konza Technopolis in Kenya

illustrates this ambition. Conceived as a “Silicon Savannah,” this new city aims to make the country an African technological hub. It integrates smart infrastructure, optimized energy and water management, and advanced digital systems to improve urban services. Konza thus embodies a desire to skip certain stages of classic urban development by directly adopting innovative and sustainable solutions, adapted to local realities (Watson, 2014; Ndemo & Weiss, 2017). Nevertheless, the most notable example continues to be Shenzhen in China. Once a small fishing community, Shenzhen has evolved into a vast city within a few decades, symbolizing swift development and creativity. The city is distinguished by its status as a key technology center, hosting many advanced companies, and by its ability to try out new urban policies. Specifically, it has rolled out extensive electric public transportation and fostered environments that encourage innovation (Vogel, 2011; Chen de’Medici, 2010). As a result, Shenzhen acts as a model for numerous emerging cities worldwide, showing that careful planning, significant investments, and a willingness to embrace new ideas can dramatically change a region. However, this example also brings up concerns, especially about social disparities, pressure on land use, and effects on the environment (Wu, 2015; Yeh, 2005).

In the end, new cities seem to be ideal settings for testing the urban areas of the future. Amidst the promises of sustainability and ongoing challenges, they embody the aspirations and limitations of a city design focused on innovation and resilience. If urbanisation allows China to project their influence on the world scale, this strategy is not without its limitations. Certainly, the components that give the BRI its strength — borrowing, overseeing infrastructure, and spreading its model — can also lead to weaknesses and pushback. In the next part, we will examine how this goal faces significant geopolitical and economic hurdles.

II. Les limites et tensions de la stratégie chinoise : Is the Belt and Road initiative and the urbanization process always a gain for Chinese FP ?

To what extent are these dynamics truly beneficial for Chinese Foreign Policy ? The underlying question of debt is crucial to understand how this strategy has been beneficial for Chinese foreign trade, but at the same time underlying criticisms. Nonetheless, this "debt diplomacy" has faced growing backlash. In many instances, increasing debt amounts have sparked worries about a country's independence and reliance on others (Brautigam, 2020). Instead of strengthening China's power, these money-related strategies can lead to suspicion and political reactions, which may ultimately harm Beijing's reputation as a friendly economic partner. .

Massive infrastructure and city projects are not free from political implications; they frequently spark local disputes. The example of the China-Pakistan Economic Corridor (CPEC) highlights this situation. Although it is marketed as a crucial growth initiative, India views it as a significant threat to its territorial rights and power in the region (Wolf, 2020).
In a wider context, China's growing presence in infrastructure has led to responses from other global powers. The United States, Japan, and the European Union have put forth alternative plans for connectivity to balance China's influence, signifying a rising competition regarding development approaches and international leadership (European Commission, 2021). This is also the case, at the regional and local level within China. The rural-urban divide and migrant integration within the *Hukou System*, which creates a Chinese household registration system that acts as an internal passport, determine where citizens can access social services. It classifies residents as rural or urban (traditionally), linking public education, healthcare, and housing to one's birthplace. In a wider context, China's growing presence in infrastructure has led to responses from other global powers.

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China presents its urban strategy as a beneficial method for promoting growth and new ideas (Xinhua, 2023). However, this view is increasingly shaded by what is happening. Numerous Chinese "smart cities" depend on sophisticated surveillance systems, which leads to worries about personal freedoms. For example, Shenzhen is frequently referenced both as a beacon of creativity and as a place with heightened digital observation (Freedom House, 2024). This approach is also shared with other countries, especially in African cities, where buildings created by China sometimes include monitoring systems. Although these technologies are effective, they bring up issues regarding governance and personal rights. On the other hand, cities in Europe like Barcelona and Berlin generally encourage urban governance models that are more open and inclusive, which makes the Chinese method less attractive. In the end, China's urban plan showcases a contradiction: it aims to boost its influence, yet its link to authoritarian actions might reduce its charm on the worldwide scene.In conclusion, China's approach to smart cities and city diplomacy shows a very mixed strategy. Though it is shown as a creative and effective way to tackle urban challenges, there are also troubling aspects. The Chinese model for smart cities, frequently described as an urban change, actually hides a less desirable truth: one that involves extensive monitoring and social exclusion, which ultimately reduce its global appeal and restrict its ability to serve as a means of soft power.

Aside from conflicts and critiques, the Belt and Road Initiative shows a more significant change in global relations: the growth of city diplomacy. Urban areas, more frequently operating independently, are becoming allies—or sometimes rivals—of nations. How is China using this situation to go around regular government systems? To what degree do city collaborations offer a different option than the BRI? These are the questions we will examine next.

III. La Belt and Road Initiative : un terrain de jeu pour la diplomatie urbaine. Comment les villes deviennent des acteurs géopolitiques dans l'ombre des États

Does the BRI's urban dimension expand city diplomacy beyond state-centric frameworks, or is it merely residual diplomacy? Through urban partnerships, China extends its influence flexibly and subtly, often bypassing traditional state structures.

China increasingly leverages its cities—Shanghai, Chengdu, Shenzhen—as tools of influence, forming "sister city" alliances with Global South hubs like Cape Town, Nairobi, and Johannesburg. These ties foster economic, cultural, and political cooperation without formal diplomacy, allowing China to project its economic model and enhance its global presence. By shifting dialogue from the national to the urban level, city diplomacy enables more pragmatic, less politicized partnerships. China has also institutionalized this approach through the Belt and Road Cities Alliance (2019), uniting cities to coordinate infrastructure, connectivity, and policy in line with the BRI.

Yet, this model faces resistance. Alternative urban networks—such as C40 (climate action) and UCLG (local governance)—promote sustainability, transparency, and participatory governance, clashing with China's state-driven, economic-focused approach. The C40 Cities Climate Leadership Group, for example, prioritizes decarbonization and ESG standards, making BRI projects less attractive to member cities. London's rejection of Chinese coal investments exemplifies this tension. While C40 embodies a horizontal, city-led governance model, it remains dependent on global supply

chains controlled by China, limiting true independence (Sassen, 2001). Can cities escape this asymmetric system, or does decentralized governance offer a real alternative to the BRI's centralized hegemony?

UCLG further challenges China's model by enabling direct city-to-city cooperation, bypassing states and traditional financial institutions. It supports Global South collaborations, such as Cape Town and São Paulo's social housing projects, demonstrating local autonomy. On migration, cities like Barcelona, Athens, and Berlin act as "sanctuary cities", offering human rights-based alternatives to the BRI's instrumentalized migration policies. These cities resist state-led security practices, affirming their own moral authority (Isin, 2000). Backed by networks like the International Cities of Refuge (ICC), they redefine migration governance, signaling a shift in power from states to municipalities (Soguk, 1999; Ridgley, 2008).

CONCLUSION :

In a nutshell, China's BRI-driven urban strategy has positioned it as a global power, enabling Beijing to project economic, technological, and political influence through infrastructure, new urban regions, and international city networks. Yet, this model faces critical shortcomings: debt reliance, geopolitical tensions, and pushback from competing powers reveal its instability. Additionally, the export of Chinese urban practices—particularly in smart cities—raises governance and privacy concerns, potentially undermining its global appeal.

The rise of urban diplomacy marks a structural shift in international relations, with cities evolving from state tools into independent actors capable of collaboration, competition, and resistance. This trend suggests a multi-layered global governance system, where power is distributed among diverse actors. Ultimately, the future global order may hinge not only on nation-led projects like the BRI but also on cross-border urban networks that redefine connectivity, growth, and rivalry. Within this context, the situation in China prompts a larger inquiry: will future global power be organized around competing nation-led projects like the BRI, or will it be increasingly influenced by cross-border urban networks that can reshape international relations? From this viewpoint, China's situation highlights a larger surge in global rivalry, increasingly centered on conflicting ideas of growth, advancement, and connectivity. This implies that determining the future global order may rely as much on those who create and construct it as on those who manage it.

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